

User Trust and Opinion Leader Interaction

The Moderating Effect of Psychological Congruence on Information Adoption

Abstract

This study investigates the relationship between user trust and opinion leader interaction in the context of social media platforms. We examine how psychological congruence moderates the effect of trust on information adoption behaviors.

1. Introduction

In the era of social media, opinion leaders play a crucial role in shaping user attitudes and behaviors. The concept of opinion leadership, first introduced by Lazarsfeld et al. (1944), has evolved significantly with the rise of digital platforms.

Trust has been identified as a fundamental determinant of information adoption in online environments (McKnight et al., 2002). However, the mechanisms through which trust influences information adoption, particularly in the context of opinion leader interactions, remain underexplored.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Opinion Leadership Theory

Opinion leadership theory posits that certain individuals, due to their expertise, social status, or media exposure, exert disproportionate influence on the attitudes and behaviors of others within their social networks (Katz & Lazarsfeld, 1955).

2.2 Trust in Online Environments

Trust in online environments encompasses both cognitive trust (based on rational assessment of capability and reliability) and affective trust (based on emotional bonds and perceived benevolence) (McAllister, 1995).

3. Methodology

We employed a mixed-methods approach combining quantitative survey data (N=1,247) with qualitative interviews (N=32) conducted across three major social media platforms.

4. Results

Our findings reveal that psychological congruence significantly moderates the relationship between user trust and information adoption ($\beta=0.34$, $p<0.001$), supporting H3.

5. Conclusion

This study contributes to the literature by demonstrating the critical role of psychological congruence in the trust-adoption relationship, offering new insights for both theory and practice in social media marketing.